PAKISTAN'S RECALIBRATION

A number of Pakistan's vulnerabilities were exposed as India struck its air bases at will. Those attacks, especially the strike on the Nur Khan air base near the Pakistan army's general headquarters in Rawalpindi, conveyed the impression that India was prepared to dismantle the Pakistani command-and-control edifice by severing functional linkages between GHQ, corps headquarters and subordinate formations through the destruction of key personnel and infrastructure. Pakistan asked for a ceasefire on May 10 because it calculated this risk, feel Indian government sources.

Another weakness lay underneath the establishment in August 2025 of the Pakistan Army Rocket Force Command (ARFC), which is built around the FATAH-series of missiles/rocket systems. The restructuring of artillery formations at Gujranwala and Pano Aqil into ARF Division (North) and ARF Division (South), along with the induction of additional missile regiments under direct GHQ control indicates past deficiencies in long-range strike capability and battlefield deterrence. Similarly, Pakistan's air defences had underperformed during Op. Sindoor. The Pakistan Air Force's (PAF) purchase of Turkish KORKUT air defence systems suggests a need to improve its aerial threat protection.

By consolidating the authority of the Pakistan army chief under the new post of the Chief of Defence Forces and abolishing the office of the chairman of the joint chiefs of staff committee, Pakistan appears to have acknowledged weaknesses in inter-services coordination. Pakistan army chief Field Marshal Asim Munir is the new CDS, with overall command of all the three services. The establishment of the National Strategic Command under an army lieutenant general also suggests an effort to restore credibility to Pakistan's nuclear posture and deterrence, which has weakened due to India's willingness to undertake military operations, brushing aside Islamabad's age-old nuclear threat. Pakistan's Strategic Mutual Defence Agreement (SMDA) with Saudi Arabia, which formalises decades-old security ties and has a clause of mutual assistance during conflict, is also seen as a deterrent against any fresh Indian action like Op. Sindoor.

LESSONS FOR PAKISTAN

The military weaknesses Indian action in Op. Sindoor exposed in Pakistan's military and its corrective measures

INDIA'S STRIKES

- **Poor inter-service** coordination; weak command-and-control structures
- **Shortcomings** in long-range precision strike capability
- **Gaps in air defence,** artillery survivability, protection of strategic assets
- **Deficiencies in surveillance,** drone warfare, real-time battlefield awareness
- **Strain on logistics,** due to force deployments along border with Afghanistan

ISLAMABAD'S FIXES

- **Command restructure** through new posts of Chief of Defence Forces and Commander, National Strategic Command
- **Creation of Pakistan** Army Rocket Force Command (ARFC)
- **Induction of Turkish** KORKUT AD systems and anti-tank missile platforms
- **Acquisition of Chinese** CH-4 and CH-5 UAVs, SA-180 loitering munitions; Z-10ME copters, SH-15 mounted artillery systems

A NEW DRONE FORCE

With most of its UAVs unable to penetrate India's AD systems, Pakistan wants to beef up its drone force. Its subsequent defence contracts with China for the long-range CH-4 and CH-5 drones and SA-180 loitering munitions indicate this. The push to develop a UAV force underscores deficiencies in intelligence, surveillance and reconnaissance (ISR) and battlefield awareness. The emphasis on ISR drones suggests that Pakistanis acknowledge their inadequate surveillance and precision engagement capabilities.

Pakistan's military purchases go far beyond the type of equipment used in Op. Sindoor—a wide range of hardware is being acquired to paper over various shortcomings, say the sources. If the procurement of Turkish OMTAS and ERYX anti-tank missile systems points toward deficiencies in anti-armour capability identified during operational assessments, the induction of Chinese Z-10ME attack helicopters indicates the need to bolster close air support abilities. Pakistani efforts to establish a new 155 mm artillery ammunition production facility point to concerns over dependence on external supply chains. The phased acquisition of over 25 regiments of Chinese SH-15 mounted gun systems is believed to reflect worries about artillery mobility and India's accurate targeting of Pakistani artillery units.

Operation Sindoor has reshaped the military posture of India and Pakistan. ■